

JOINING HANDS: Zardari (left) with Sharif at Naudero

a small disco. His only involvement with student politics was as part of a small-time gang of friends who, like his father at the time, held anti-PPP views and functioned mostly as local bullies. After completing school, Zardari tried his hand in the construction business but lost money in the endeavour, the still-standing Asif Plaza a testament to that time.

All that changed, however, with his arranged marriage to Benazir Bhutto in December 1987. There was much speculation about why the Bhutto family had chosen a "political nobody" for the daughter, whose star was on the rise since her triumphant return from exile under General Zia-ul-Haq's dictatorship. There had certainly been other potential suitors. But Zardari was dashing and urbane and after General Zia hanged Zulfikar, Hakim Ali had become part of the anti-Zia Movement for Restoration of Democracy. Most people accepted the marriage as a political necessity in a male-dominated society that may not have looked kindly upon a young, unmarried woman as a political leader. From relative obscurity, the fun-loving, polo-playing Zardari was catapulted to instant fame.

When Bhutto became prime minister after General Zia's death and elections in 1988, Zardari certainly helped her negotiate the largely male world of the bureaucracy and politicians. As a man, he was able to become part of the kind of back-slapping, old-boys backroom clubs that Bhutto could never have been part of. Though he held no official post, he set up his own secretariat in the PM House's annex and became adept at the kind of political manoeuvring that was needed to run coalition governments. His friends spoke of him fondly as "*yaaron ka yaar* (a friend of friends)". Unfortunately, this also stoked rumours of corruption within the PM House and the general feeling in Islamabad was that the path to government contracts led through him. When Bhutto's government was dismissed on corruption charges in 1990, hundreds of stories appeared in the press about the nepotistic granting of sugar mill licences and unsecured bank loans to Zardari's friends, illegal

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CHARGES AGAINST ZARDARI

Some of the cases may be dismissed if the National Reconciliation Ordinance continues to be part of the law.

MURTAZA BHUTTO MURDER CASE:

Accused of conspiring to murder his wife's brother. Trial is pending.

JUSTICE NIZAM MURDER CASE:

Indicted by the Nawaz Sharif regime for gunning down Sindh High Court judge Nizam Ahmed and his son, tortured by police and accused of attempting suicide before being given bail in 1999. The case is pending.

ALAM BALOCH MURDER CASE:

Accused of being involved in the killing of former Federal secretary Alam Baloch in 1997.

SGS-COTECNA CASE:

Charged with receiving millions of dollars for giving contracts to two Swiss companies. He was convicted, then judgement was set aside. Retrial is on.

ARY GOLD CASE:

Charged with receiving kickbacks from a Dubai company in return for an exclusive licence to import gold into Pakistan.

POLISH TRACTORS CASE:

Allegedly took kickbacks on low-cost tractor imports.

STEEL MILL CASE:

Accused of taking bribes from the former chairman of Pakistan Steel Mill, Sajjad Hussain.

STILL THE BOSS:
Musharraf has some cards up his sleeve



allotment of public lands, and kickbacks in other government deals. He was put behind bars and spent 18 months in jail until Sharif's government was dismissed by President Ishaq Khan in April 1993. When PPP once again swept into power, Zardari first became environment minister in Bhutto's new government and then was handed the investment portfolio.

His talent for political wheeling and dealing was on display in the alliances he managed to cobble together—to have PPP's nominee Farooq Leghari